

Skullcandy Method 360 ANC

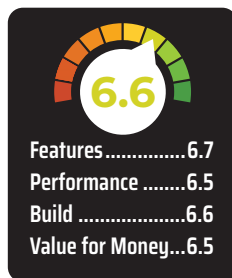
Standing out is easy, but can it stand apart?

Earbuds across price ranges have been trying to differentiate themselves with unique designs and partnerships with established audio brands. Skullcandy has chosen to go its own way with the Method 360 ANC. The new TWS earphones pair was launched recently in India, priced at Rs 12499. It has an unconventional charging case that can be hung from your backpack. And there's the 'Sound by Bose' branding, which immediately raises expectations. Together, they make the Method 360 ANC one of the more intriguing launches in the premium TWS space. But does it all come together for a good pair of earphones? You'll have the answer here.

DESIGN THAT STANDS OUT

Most earbuds have compact pebble-or squircle-shaped cases. Skullcandy has given the Method 360 a long rectangular case that resembles a vape. Some bystanders asked and gawked at what this thing I was holding. It has a translucent surface with a grooved finish. This was good to hold. But it is noticeably larger and not something you can easily slide into your jeans/pant pocket.

With the built-in carabiner, the Method 360 is meant to be hung from a bag or belt loop. While that's certainly distinctive, I wasn't comfortable doing so. A case hanging in plain sight feels more vulnerable to accidental knocks, scratches or even theft in crowded places. But I know some people who would love to hang it, as it is sure to be a talking point.



It feels like Skullcandy has prioritised style and identity over portability. Even while I was in a crowded metro, taking out the earbuds was tough. The sliding mechanism to open the case felt cool but slightly cumbersome. Putting the earbuds back in also didn't always come naturally to me.

The earbuds themselves are also a tad bigger in size than most earbuds out there. But they are lightweight, and the rubber earwings offer a comfortable fit. They wouldn't quickly fall off during light workouts and movements. You can choose between the different ear tips and silicone wings present in the box for the right combination. The larger size of the earbuds offers more surface for touch/tap gestures, which again matters a lot in everyday use.

Last but not least, the Method 360 ANC earbuds support an IPX4 rating, which means you don't have to worry about sweat or light rain, although some

competitors offer better protection against dust as well.

SOUND BY BOSE PROMISE VS PERFORMANCE

Ever since Bose began licensing its 'Sound by Bose' audio tuning, we've started seeing the branding appear on some earbuds. Method 360 also gets this, and as per Skullcandy, the partnership includes Bose engineers' involvement in not just audio architecture but also the design of the ear gels. The claims include 'high-fidelity audio experience defined by clarity of sound and depth of range,' but that's not exactly what we get. The sound signature is more bass-forward than balanced, which is fine for listening to hip-hop, EDM, workout playlists, and Bollywood pop. But even the quality of the bass isn't too deep or energetic.

In 'Matador' by Jayo, the rumble in the beginning portion of the track isn't prominent on the Method 360, while its strong presence is meant to create an exciting sense of depth and energy. The same is true for the bass drops on Jailer 2's 'One Name.' They don't dig as deep as they should, making the drops feel less impactful than they are meant to.

The high notes of the synth beats on The Weeknd's 'Open Hearts' aren't clear either. The soundstage is very narrow, too. So, a track like Hangova from 'DC' sounds confined. While the overall loudness sounds low when compared to our reference earbuds at the same volume level, the vocals by Anirudh Ravichander in this Hangova track sound recessed on the Skullcandy pair.

Overall, the Method 360 delivers an easy-going sound with more lower-end emphasis but doesn't try too hard to impress. Just don't expect the kind of refined listening experience the 'Sound by Bose' branding might lead you to anticipate.

SKULLCANDY APP: AMPLE CUSTOMISATION

The app has a simple dark-themed interface with colourful accents that